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EMPLOYING PROFESSIONALS AND HOMEGROWN TERRORISTS GIVES PAKISTAN PLAUSIBLE DENIABILITY, AS IT PORTRAYS A LARGER KASHMIRI DISENCHANTMENT WITH THE INDIAN STATE

reportedly radicalised through these groups. Early conversations focused on "aazaadi"for Kashmir and the suppression of Kashmiris, then shifted to a global jihad narrative and calls to avenge injustice. The police also point to a strong degree of self-radicalisation among the doctors.

Their Pakistani handlers, whom Indian agencies are trying to identify, are also said to have met Umar and Irfan during a trip to Turkiye in 2022, a visit that marked the module's formal consolidation. On returning, the group resolved to expand operations across India. Ganai was asked to join Al-Fatah, where Umar was working; Rather sought the Saharanpur posting. Other members were deployed to various states for recruitment and logistics. Agencies are now mapping every individual who interacted with the module's key members. They will also analyse a mobile tower dump around the Red Fort to trace Umar's communication between 3 pm and 6:30 pm, the critical window before he drove the explosives-laden car out of the parking lot. The data is expected to reveal last-minute instructions and handler contacts.

Security agencies say the plan to carry out strikes gathered pace after Op Sindoor. Key terrorist organisations like the JeM, Lashkar-e-Toiba and Hizbul Mujahideen, hit by the Indian armed forces, are being moved to new bases deep inside Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KPK) province, near the Afghan frontier. Moreover, the JeM was found to be openly seeking donations through digital banking transaction platforms to rebuild the terror infrastructure Op Sindoor destroyed. Officials believe the involvement of educated professionals, including doctors, indicates a shift in JeM's strategy to rebuild its networks within India through new channels of recruitment and radicalisation.

Radicalising women seems to be another part of JEM's new strategy. Intelligence sources have tracked down a 21-minute audio recording of Masood Azhar, delivered recently at Markaz Usman o Ali in Bahawalpur, which reveals an elaborate plan to indoctrinate, train and deploy women under a newly-formed wing called the Jamaat-ul-Mominat led by his sister Sadiya. Shaheen, the woman doctor arrested from Faridabad, is alleged to be part of it as well. In the core group is Afeera Farooq, widow of Umar Farooq, the mastermind of the Pulwama bombing. These women are reportedly conducting daily online indoctrination sessions, recruiting and motivating new female adherents under what JeM describes as its "Shoba-e-Dawat" campaign.

How India Should Respond

Indian security experts are viewing these developments with growing concern. Says Lt Gen. D.P. Pandey, former commander of the Srinagar-based Chinar Corps, "The big challenge lies in tackling the 'white-collar terrorists' who create and sustain the network of militancy in J&K. They will become the real factories of terrorism. They identify vulnerable youth, groom and radicalise them and, under directions from handlers abroad, ensure they are armed and ready to strike." Security forces are focusing on neutralising armed terrorists, and not on those who operating behind the scenes and perpetuating the ideology of violence, he adds.